TEXORA · COURSE NOTES · LECTURE SHEET

Community Development

The organised effort by which a community improves its own life with outside support but under its own leadership — its meaning and scope, its working process, and the programmes that made Bangladesh a world laboratory of the idea.

HUM-2209 · SOCIOLOGY AND HUMAN ECOLOGY · TOPIC 7 · LEVEL 2 TERM 2

1. Meaning and definition

A **community** is a group of people living in a locality, sharing common institutions and a sense of belonging — the village is the classic case in Bangladesh. **Community development** is the process of improving that community's economic, social and cultural life *through the community's own participation*, normally joined with technical and financial help from government or voluntary agencies.

The United Nations' classic definition (1950s) remains the one examiners quote: community development is *"a process where community members come together to take collective action and generate solutions to common problems,"* — in the fuller official wording, a process by which the efforts of the people themselves are united with those of governmental authorities to improve the economic, social and cultural conditions of communities and to integrate them into the life of the nation. Two halves must both be present: **people's own effort** and **outside support**. Charity without participation is relief, not development; participation without any resources is exhortation, not development.

The essential marks of the idea:

- **Participation** — the people plan, contribute and decide; they are subjects, not objects, of the programme.
- **Felt needs first** — work begins from needs the community itself feels, not from a list imported by an office.
- **Self-help** — outside aid is a supplement to local labour, materials and money, never a substitute for them.
- **Local leadership** — the process must grow leaders from within, so the work survives the visitor's departure.
- **Whole-community view** — health, farming, education, roads and incomes are treated as one fabric, not as separate departmental files.

2. Scope and subject matter

The **scope** of community development is as wide as community life itself. In the rural setting of most programmes it spans: agriculture and livestock (better seed, irrigation, cooperatives); health and sanitation (safe water, latrines, immunisation, nutrition); education (adult literacy, schools); housing and village infrastructure (roads, culverts, embankments); small and cottage industry and credit; women's development and family welfare; youth and cultural activities; and local government and cooperative organisation. In towns it takes urban forms: slum improvement, waste management, tenants' and workers' welfare.

Its **subject matter** as a field of study combines parts of sociology (community structure, leadership, group behaviour), economics (rural production and credit), public administration (how agencies reach the village), agriculture and health sciences, and social work method — especially the skills of working *with* groups rather than merely delivering services *to* them. This is why community development is sometimes called applied sociology with its sleeves rolled up.

3. Principles

PRINCIPLE	WHAT IT DEMANDS IN PRACTICE
Start with felt needs	The first project should be what the village asks for — a well, a culvert — because success there builds the trust for harder projects later
Self-help and local resources	Every scheme should carry a visible local contribution of labour, land, materials or cash
Participation of all sections	Women, the poor and minority groups must be in the room — a programme captured by the already-powerful develops the wrong community
Indigenous leadership	Identify and train local leaders; the outside worker advises and withdraws
Coordination	Health, agriculture, education and credit workers pull together instead of running rival empires in one village
Gradual, sustainable pace	Change at the speed people can absorb; build institutions that continue after the project ends
Evaluation	Results are checked with the community, and failures admitted and redesigned

4. The process of community development

Programmes differ, but the working process follows a recognisable sequence:

1. **Entry and rapport.** The worker enters the community, lives at its level, listens, and wins trust — through small services, presence at its joys and crises, never through promises.
2. **Study and needs assessment.** Together with residents, the worker surveys the community: resources, problems, existing leaders and organisations. The people must see their own situation in the findings.
3. **Discussion and prioritisation.** Felt needs are debated in open meeting; one achievable first project is chosen, so that an early success can teach the habit of collective action.
4. **Planning.** The community and the supporting agencies agree who does what, what the community contributes, what outside help supplies, and by when.
5. **Organisation.** A village committee, cooperative or group is formed or strengthened to carry the plan; local leaders are trained for their roles.
6. **Implementation.** The work is done — wells dug, classes held, loans disbursed — with the community's contribution in front and the worker's expertise behind.
7. **Monitoring and evaluation.** Progress is reviewed with the people; mistakes are corrected openly, which is itself a development lesson.
8. **Consolidation and withdrawal.** The local institution takes full charge; the worker moves on. A programme that cannot be left behind has not developed a community — it has adopted one.

5. Community development programmes in Bangladesh

Bangladesh is one of the world's great laboratories of community development; four landmarks carry most examination answers.

PROGRAMME	WHEN / BY WHOM	CONTRIBUTION
V-AID (Village Agricultural and Industrial Development)	1950s, government of Pakistan	The first large attempt to carry development services to the village through multipurpose village workers; ambitious, but top-heavy and short on real participation — the cautionary tale of the field.
The Comilla Model	1960s, Pakistan (later Bangladesh) Academy for Rural Development at Comilla, led by Akhter Hameed Khan	The classic success: two-tier village cooperatives, a thana training and development centre, works and irrigation programmes — built patiently on farmers' own organisation; studied worldwide and the ancestor of later rural development here.

BRDB and cooperative programmes	From the 1970s–80s, Bangladesh Rural Development Board	Carried the cooperative idea nationally: village societies, women's cooperatives, rural works and credit through government machinery.
NGO community programmes	From the 1970s onward — BRAC, Grameen Bank and thousands of others (Topic 9)	Group-based development of the poor, especially women: microcredit, health, education and legal awareness organised village by village; Bangladesh became the world's reference case for NGO-led development.

Government social welfare services, local government bodies (Union Parishads) and later programmes of rural infrastructure and social protection continue the line. The recurring lesson across seventy years: programmes succeed in proportion as they organise the poor themselves, and fail in proportion as they merely deliver things to them.

6. Problems and limits

- **Elite capture** — committees and credit cornered by the locally powerful, bending benefits away from the poorest.
- **Dependency** — communities waiting for the agency instead of acting; the opposite of the founding idea.
- **Top-down targets** — numbers fixed in the capital (so many latrines, so many loans) that staff satisfy on paper while the process dies.
- **Short project cycles** — donors and projects arrive and leave faster than institutions can grow.
- **Faction and politics** — village party and factional splits imported into development committees.

None of these refutes the approach; they define the craft of the community development worker, which is precisely to design against them.

7. Glossary — key terms of this topic

TERM	MEANING
Community	A group sharing a locality, common institutions and a sense of belonging.
Felt need	A need as experienced and expressed by the community itself, the proper starting point of a programme.
Self-help	The principle that development work must rest mainly on the community's own labour and resources, aided from outside.

Elite capture	The cornering of a programme's benefits by the locally powerful.
Cooperative	An association owned and run by its members for their joint economic benefit — the Comilla Model's basic unit.
Microcredit	Very small loans to poor borrowers, usually in groups, pioneered at scale in Bangladesh.

8. Key points and summary

- Community development = people's own organised effort + outside agency support, aimed at the whole of community life; participation and felt needs are its non-negotiable core.
- Its scope covers agriculture, health, education, infrastructure, credit and local organisation; its subject matter blends sociology, economics, administration and social work.
- The process runs: entry and rapport → study of needs → joint planning → local organisation → implementation → evaluation → local takeover and withdrawal.
- Bangladesh's landmarks: V-AID (the warning), the Comilla Model under Akhter Hameed Khan (the classic method), BRDB cooperatives (the state channel), and NGO group-based development (the world-scale experiment).
- Its chronic enemies — elite capture, dependency, paper targets — are design problems, answered by the principles in section 3.

9. Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. State the UN definition of community development and identify its two essential components.
2. An agency offers a village a free tube-well, installed by its own contractor, if the village provides only the site. Which principles of community development does this offer satisfy, and which does it violate?
3. Arrange and briefly justify the order: evaluation, entry and rapport, implementation, needs assessment, local organisation.
4. Compare V-AID and the Comilla Model in three points: organisation used, role of the villager, judged outcome.
5. “A programme that cannot be left behind has not developed a community.” Explain.
6. A village committee's loans keep going to the chairman's relatives. Name the problem and propose two design remedies drawn from section 3.

Answer key

1. Community development is the process by which community members take collective action on their common problems, uniting their own efforts with those of government authorities to improve their economic, social and cultural conditions. Components: (1) the people's own organised participation; (2) technical and material support from outside agencies.
2. Satisfies: responds to a real need (safe water) and brings outside resources. Violates: self-help (no local contribution beyond the site, so no ownership), participation (no role in deciding or doing), and local leadership (contractor-led delivery builds no institution). Predictable result: breakdowns unrepaired once the agency leaves.
3. Entry and rapport → needs assessment → local organisation → implementation → evaluation. Justification: trust before data; the community's own organisation must exist before work can be carried; evaluation closes the cycle and corrects the next round.
4. Organisation: V-AID relied on government multipurpose workers; Comilla built farmers' own two-tier cooperatives. Villager's role: V-AID — recipient of services; Comilla — member, saver, borrower and decision-maker. Outcome: V-AID faded as top-heavy; Comilla became a studied model that shaped later rural development nationally.
5. Development means capacity that stays: leadership, organisation, skill and habits of collective action resident in the community. If withdrawal ends the work, what existed was a service delivered to a place, not a community developed — the test of success is precisely that the worker becomes unnecessary.
6. The problem is elite capture. Remedies: participation of all sections — reserved places or separate groups for the poor and for women in decisions; transparency — beneficiary lists and accounts read out in open meeting (accept also: rotating leadership, outside audit).

Texora — course notes prepared from the official syllabus of B.Sc. in Textile Engineering · Made by Sakib